Case Study 1 - Atari

Student submission

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Worksheet link

https://courses.ethereallab.app/assignment/v4/IT265-001-F2026/case-study-1-atari/jtc62

Grading link

https://courses.ethereallab.app/assignment/v4/IT265-001-F2026/case-study-1-atari/grading/jtc62

AI disclosure: Completed; 1 entry; 0 declared AI use; 1 declared no AI use; policy v1

Game Overview

Game details

Response prompt

Identify the game: title, developer, publisher, original platform, genre, and release date. Note the version you played if different.

Submitted response

Title: Battlezone (Atari 2600 Version)
Developer: Atari, Mike Feinstein, Brad Rice
Publisher: Atari
Original Platform: Arcade (2600 is a port of the 1980 Arcade Original)
Genre: Action, Simulation
https://atarionline.org/atari-2600/battlezone
Release Date: 1983

History and industry

Response prompt

Explain the historical context of the release and where the game fit in the industry at that time.

Submitted response

This version of Battlezone was released in 1983 and was ported to platforms other than the Atari 2600 such as the Commodore 64, ZX Spectrum, Apple II, and IBM PC compatibles. At this time in history, there was actually a crash in the video game market, with there being an oversaturation of games for these consoles, and Atari couldn't replicate the 3D vector graphics used on the Arcade original and had to use colorful sprites instead, swapping off from a first-person periscope view to a third person view.
https://www.cgcgrading.com/news/articles/the-great-video-game-crash-of-1983-part-1-5Vr5Vqkh9JnvoXOAY3l5LV/

Contemporary comparison

Response prompt

Compare the game with a similar game from the same period, explaining a meaningful design similarity or difference.

Submitted response

Another game from the same period would be Activision's "Robot Tank", which had gameplay that was practically similar to Atari's Battlezone. Something that differs from Atari's Battlezone compared to Robot Tank is that instead of being just a arcade shooter, Robot Tank aims for a more strategic and tactical approach towards gameplay. The game has many more features compared to Battlezone such as damage zones on the tank and different weather conditions.

Gameplay Mechanics And Level Design

Core gameplay mechanics

Response prompt

Explain how the core actions and rules shape a recurring player decision. Support the explanation with a gameplay example.

Submitted response

In the version of the game that I played, the player is placed in an empty field against an endless wave of constantly spawning enemy tanks, fighters and UFOs. The player is locked to a certain field of view in front of them and must rely on a radar on the top of the display to located enemies and destroy them before they shoot first. The player has 5 lives with the goal of getting the highest score possible. The enemy tanks and fighters are the only actively hostile entities while the UFOs are fast, harmless entities that reward extra score when destroyed, but disappear after a while. This has the player face a dilemma when both an enemy tank and UFO appear on screen, with the player having to decide on whether to risk aiming for the fast-moving UFO and risk losing a life to the tank, or vice versa with destroying the immediate threat but risk losing out on extra score opportunity.

Level design

Response prompt

Explain how the layout, obstacles, or progression affect a player decision or challenge. Use a specific example.

Submitted response

In the original version of Battlezone, the field had different types of cover that can be used by both players and enemies, but in the Atari 2600 version, the field was barren of any cover, leaving the player to rely on outmaneuvering the enemy and avoiding their shots. As the game progresses, enemies start to spawn faster, and (at least from the score that I reached) enemy tanks are replaced with super tanks that start to ramp up in speed, making them harder to hit while they constantly maintain a target on the player. Thus, the time in the decision making process between a player trying to aim for UFOs or Tanks is shortened, increasing the challenge.

Graphic And Audio Design

Visual design

Response prompt

Explain how a visual design choice affects the experience or communicates information during play. Use a specific example.

Submitted response

Compared to the original game which was largely in black and green, with black being used for the ground and background, and green highlights being used to highlight background mountains, enemies, and cover. As for the Atari 2600 version, the field is colorful with the player's tank being colored green whilst enemy tanks, fighters, and UFOs are blue, yellow, and red respectively. As for being tied into gameplay, there is a little marker right above the center of the screen that changes color when the "crosshair" is hovering over an enemy, signaling the player that it would be a good idea to fire then. The game also features a radar on the top of the display that shows which direction the player is facing along with white dots signifying where nearby enemies are.

Sound design

Response prompt

Explain how music, sound effects, or their absence affect the experience or communicate information during play. Use a specific example.

Submitted response

During play, there is a distinct sound effect that plays when both the player's tank and the enemy tanks fire off a round, letting the player know if a target not within their field of view is attacking them. Another audio cue that helps in gameplay is that when enemies spawn, regardless if they are a tank, fighter, or UFO, a specific noise rings out to let the

player know. Lastly, when any entity on the field is destroyed, be it player or enemy, an explosion sound effect plays, which can help a player know if a shot they let off before looking away from the target they shot at was successfully hit.

Narrative And Storytelling

Narrative and setting

Response prompt

Explain how the setting and story relate to play. Describe key events if present, or explain the effect of a limited or absent story.

Submitted response

The effect of having an absent story allows for the user to focus solely on the actual gameplay experience. This was helpful since this was a port of an arcade game where gameplay was the main focus for short play sessions rather than pursuing a story experience.

Character development

Response prompt

Explain how character development relates to gameplay, or how limited or absent development affects the experience.

Submitted response

Since there are no characters in Battlezone, with the player and enemies only being vehicles, the player can focus purely on gameplay and achieving a high score. However, you could say that the presence of super tanks later on in gameplay as the player racks up points shows the character development of the enemy tanks and how they need to bring out more elite units to take the player out.

Impact And Reception

Reception

Response prompt

Summarize the critical and player reception using identifiable reviews or feedback. Distinguish release-era reception from later reactions.

Submitted response

Of the era, player feedback behind Battlezone (Atari 2600) were comparing it to Activision's Robot Tank and how that game had more features than both the newly ported Battlezone and the original. Some other things noted were how the Battlezone for the Atari 2600's artstyle dumbed down enemy tank turning from 3D renders to sprites that only swap sides that they're facing instead of smoothly turning like in the original arcade game.
https://www.atarihq.com/reviews/2600/battlezone.php

Industry and cultural impact

Response prompt

Explain the game's industry impact and cultural significance using research. Avoid claiming influence that the sources do not establish.

Submitted response

Battlezone (1980) was one of the first mainstream successes of an arcade game that let the player traverse and immerse themselves in a 3D landscape. Not only that, but apparently the game was so influential that it caught the eye of the US military who would commission Atari to create a special version of Battlezone titled the "Bradley Trainer" to help train soldiers using a simulated version of the M2 Bradley military vehicle.
https://spectrum.ieee.org/battlezone
https://www.safestuff.com/bradley.htm

Reflection

Fun and experience

Response prompt

Explain what made the game enjoyable or frustrating for you, using a gameplay example.

Submitted response

What made the game enjoyable for me is trying to use the skills I have learned playing with modern game tanks in Battlezone and was pleased to see that they properly work. Another satisfying thing is predicting and landing shots on moving targets, for example, there were times where I correctly predicted where to shoot against a fast moving UFO.

Learning and research

Response prompt

Reflect on what this case study taught you and how easy or difficult it was to find dependable information.

Submitted response

Something that this case study had taught me was how innovative games were back then. As for finding dependable information, it was a little hard to do so, especially the part regarding original reviews of the original 1980 Arcade release.